

Suicide pill

BRITAIN

The British sent agents into Nazi-occupied Europe to liaise with local resistance fighters. Each agent carried a suicide pill to swallow if captured.

Sniper rifle

USSR

The Soviet Red Army made extensive use of snipers, especially in the Battle of Stalingrad. They used a standard-issue Mosin-Nagant infantry rifle with a telescopic sight.

telescopic sight

Improvised boots

GERMANY

German troops invading the USSR in 1941 were not equipped to face the Russian winter. Some made straw boots to protect against frostbite.

viewing window shows code letters



Civilian ration card

GERMANY

Shortages of food, fuel, and other essentials led most combatant countries to introduce rationing. This German ration card is for meat.



Red Cross parcel

BRITAIN

Prisoners of war received Red Cross food parcels. As a result, by the end of the war, Allied POWs were better fed than their captors.

plugboard; its setting can be altered to change the cipher

Anti-tank mine

GERMANY

This Teller mine had a fuse activated by the pressure of tank tracks. Over three million of these mines were made in World War II.

Enigma cipher machine

GERMANY

The Germans believed messages encrypted by Enigma were secure, but with the help of an early electromechanical computer, Allied codebreakers cracked the code.

Blackout poster

GERMANY

A dramatic poster calls on German citizens to observe blackout regulations during air raids. The slogan says "The enemy sees your light! Make it dark!"

Desert headgear

NEW ZEALAND

The Long Range Desert Group, set up by the British, was initially formed of New Zealanders. They found Arab-style headgear a good defense against desert conditions.

pressure activation plate



Nuclear relic

JAPAN

This melted glass bottle shows the extreme heat generated by the US atom bomb that destroyed Hiroshima on August 6, 1945.



scorpion badge of Long Range Desert Group

